

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 37

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator describes the afternoon her grandmother gathered the family in her kitchen to teach them a recipe she had kept in her head for fifty years.

1

The note that arrived in the family group chat that Saturday was, on the face of it, ordinary. **Come at three. Bring nothing.** My grandmother did not often send messages, and when she did, they were brief to the point of abruptness. None of us thought to ask what the occasion was. We assumed, as one does, that there would be many more such afternoons. I have learned since that assumptions of this kind are a kind of debt that one is, sooner or later, asked to repay.

2

The kitchen, when we arrived, was already warm. A heavy pot sat waiting on the back of the stove, lid tilted, breathing out the first thin curl of steam. On the counter, in a long disciplined row, stood seven small bowls: cumin, coriander, turmeric, fenugreek, a knot of fresh ginger, a head of garlic broken into cloves, and a little hill of salt. My grandmother stood behind them in the apron she had worn for as long as any of us could remember, faded almost to the colour of the wall. She did not look at the spices. She looked at us.

3

“Today,” she said, “I am going to teach you the curry.” She said it the way another woman might have announced a marriage. The five grandchildren shuffled forward; my mother and my aunt, leaning in the doorway, exchanged a glance I did not understand at the time. My grandmother had cooked this dish on every birthday, every reunion, every long homecoming, for as far back as memory reached. None of us had ever been shown how. The recipe, she liked to say, lived in her head, and her head was not going anywhere. She said that less often now.

4

She began without ceremony. She did not weigh anything. She tipped cumin into her palm, looked at

it, added a little more, and shook it into the pot, where it muttered and darkened almost at once. The kitchen filled, in three quick breaths, with a smell so familiar that I felt my eyes sting before I had understood why. “You smell it,” she said, without turning. “When you smell it, the cumin is ready. Not before, not after.” She moved on to the coriander. She did not raise her voice once. She gave each instruction as though she were handing us a small, fragile object across a table.

5

Halfway through, when the onions had gone from white to gold and the kitchen had the heavy, patient sweetness that I associated with her, she stepped back from the stove and laid the wooden spoon on the counter. “Lina,” she said quietly. My youngest cousin, who is twelve and whose ears had gone pink under the attention, took the spoon. My grandmother did not say **don’t burn it** or **be careful**. She said, “Stir from the bottom. The bottom is where it sticks. You will know when it is right.” Then she folded her hands in front of her apron and watched. She did not interfere again.

6

I noticed, in the half hour that followed, things I had never noticed before. My grandmother’s hands rested very lightly on the counter, as if she were grateful for it. She corrected Lina only twice, and only by humming — a low, considering **mm** when the heat needed to come down, and a small approving sound when the spices were folded in. My mother had gone very still by the doorway. My aunt was writing, in tiny careful handwriting on the back of an envelope, everything her mother said. I do not think any of us looked at our phones for the whole of that afternoon.

7

When at last the curry was done, my grandmother tasted it from Lina’s spoon. She closed her eyes for a long second. Then she opened them, looked at my cousin, and nodded once. “Yours now,” she said. We ate at the long table in the next room, eight of us, in the slow honest way of people who know they are eating something that will not come again in quite the same form. My grandmother ate less than the rest of us. She watched, mostly. Once, she reached across and laid her hand briefly over Lina’s, and Lina, for the first time that afternoon, looked frightened, and then did not.

8

At the door, when we left, she said only the things she always said. **Drive carefully. Text when you are home. Take the leftovers.** It was my aunt, later that evening, who showed me the envelope she had been writing on. It had eleven items on it, in my grandmother’s order, with no measurements at all — only verbs, and the occasional small note in brackets: **(the bottom is where it sticks)**. I have made the curry several times since. I do not pretend that mine is hers. But the smell, when the cumin goes in, is exactly the same smell, and that, I have come to think, is what she was teaching us all along.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says that her grandmother’s messages were “brief to the point of abruptness.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about how the grandmother usually communicated. [2]

2. The narrator says that “assumptions of this kind are a kind of debt that one is, sooner or later, asked to repay.” Explain what this sentence suggests about the narrator’s feelings **now**, looking back. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that suggest the grandmother had prepared the kitchen carefully **before** the family arrived. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The grandmother announces the lesson “the way another woman might have announced a marriage.” What does this comparison tell us about how she viewed the recipe? [2]

5. The narrator writes that her grandmother used to say “the recipe lived in her head, and her head was not going anywhere,” but adds that “she said that less often now.”

(a) What does this final sentence quietly suggest? [1]

(b) Why do you think the writer ends the paragraph with it rather than stating the idea openly? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator describes the cumin as something that “muttered and darkened” in the pot. Explain how the language used in this paragraph makes the cooking feel like a **living, almost human** event. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 4. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. The grandmother does not say “don’t burn it” or “be careful.” What does her **choice not** to say these things tell us about her attitude towards Lina at this moment? [2]

8. What does the detail that the grandmother “folded her hands in front of her apron and watched” suggest about how she felt as Lina took over? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 6 that suggests the family understood the importance of the afternoon, even though no one said so out loud. [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator describes the family as eating “in the slow honest way of people who know they are eating something that will not come again in quite the same form.” Explain, in your own words, what this sentence tells us about the mood at the table. [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the disappearing tradition of letter-writing in the age of instant messaging.

1

For most of recorded history, a letter was the only way that one mind could reach another across a distance. Generals planned campaigns by letter; lovers separated by oceans courted by letter; mothers learned of their sons' deaths by letter. The practice was so universal that until the middle of the twentieth century, even modest households kept a small wooden writing slope, with paper, blotter, and ink, somewhere within reach. Today, that slope, if it survives at all, is more likely to be displayed as an antique than used as a tool. In Britain, the number of stamped personal letters sent each year has fallen by more than seventy per cent in two decades. The decline has been not gradual but headlong.

2

On the face of it, the cause is obvious. A text message is free, arrives in seconds, and demands almost nothing of its sender. An email costs nothing to send to twenty recipients at once. Why, the argument runs, would anyone trouble themselves with paper, postage, and the slow agony of waiting? Yet the conclusion that follows — that the letter is simply an old technology defeated by a better one — deserves more careful examination. For something, as anyone who has received an unexpected handwritten note will testify, is plainly being lost in the exchange.

3

The first loss is **slowness**. A letter, by its nature, takes time to write and time to arrive. The writer is forced to think before committing words to the page, because crossing out is awkward and re-writing is laborious. The reader, in turn, knows that the words in front of them have been considered, perhaps re-considered, certainly not produced on the impulse of a thumb. A letter is therefore a more careful object than a text message — slower to make, slower to consume, and, very often, kinder. The historian Lucy Mangan has observed that “no one has ever sent an angry letter that they did not regret writing”, because the act of writing it took long enough to outlive the anger.

4

The second loss is **archival**. Letters, unlike messages, are durable. Generations of historians have reconstructed lives, friendships, wars, and intimacies almost entirely from boxes of saved correspondence found in attics. The letters of Vincent van Gogh to his brother Theo, for example, run to more than nine hundred pages and form the most complete record we have of any artist's inner life. By contrast, the average text message survives roughly until its owner buys a new phone. Cloud storage offers some protection, but the format is fragile: a single forgotten password, a single deleted account, and decades of conversation simply cease to exist. Future historians, attempting to write the lives of our generation, may find their richest subjects almost mute.

5

A third, quieter loss is what the writer Jenny Diski called “the ceremony of attention”. When one sits down to write a letter, one is, for a few minutes at least, doing only one thing, and doing it for one named person. The phone is not pinging. The screen does not divide one's gaze among twelve different conversations. The recipient, in turn, receives an object — folded, addressed, stamped — that has been made by hand, however imperfectly, for them alone. A text, however affectionate, cannot offer this. It arrives in a stream with takeaway receipts and software updates, and is read, almost always, while doing something else.

6

Against this loss, small countercurrents have begun to flow. School penpal schemes, once dismissed as quaint, have been revived in dozens of countries, often to link children across cultures or generations.

“Slow-mail” smartphone apps — which deliberately delay the delivery of a message by several days, mimicking the post — have attracted, somewhat surprisingly, hundreds of thousands of users. Stationery sales, after a long decline, have begun to creep upwards again; one British retailer reported that sales of writing paper to under-thirties grew by eighteen per cent in 2024. None of this restores the letter to its former centrality. But it does suggest that the appetite for considered, personal, handwritten correspondence has not vanished — it has simply gone underground, waiting to be recognised.

7

What, then, might an ordinary person do? Probably very little, and very simply. One could write, perhaps once a month, to someone whom one has been meaning to thank, or to congratulate, or merely to think about for the length of a page. One could keep, in a single drawer, the letters one receives, however few. One could teach a child to address an envelope, a small skill that more and more adults can no longer perform. None of these acts will, on its own, reverse the trend. But each one is a small, deliberate refusal — a quiet insistence that not every conversation we have with another human being should take place at the speed of a passing thought.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that the decline of letter-writing has been “not gradual but headlong.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about the **speed** of the decline. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** reasons why text messages and emails appear to have replaced letters. [2]

14. The writer says that the idea that the letter is “simply an old technology defeated by a better one” deserves “more careful examination.” What is the writer suggesting by this phrase? [1]

From Paragraph 3

15. Explain, in your own words, why the writer says that a letter is “very often, kinder” than a text message. [2]

16. The historian Lucy Mangan claims that “no one has ever sent an angry letter that they did not regret writing.” Explain what this quotation contributes to the writer’s argument in Paragraph 3. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that future historians “may find their richest subjects almost mute.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

From Paragraph 5

- 18.** The writer quotes Jenny Diski’s phrase “the ceremony of attention.”
- (a) Explain what this phrase suggests about the act of writing a letter. [1]
 - (b) Why is the word **ceremony** particularly effective here? [1]

From Paragraph 6

19. Give **two** pieces of evidence from Paragraph 6 that suggest letter-writing may be returning, at least in small ways. [2]

20. The writer says that the appetite for handwritten correspondence “has simply gone underground.” What does the word **underground** suggest here? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends by calling each small act “a small, deliberate refusal.” Explain what is **effective** about the word **refusal** in this final sentence. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **what is being lost as letter-writing disappears**, and **what small movements are helping to keep the practice alive**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

As letter-writing fades, what is being lost is ...

— END OF PAPER —